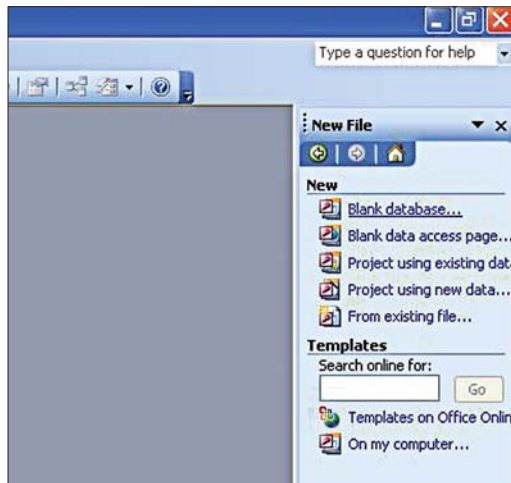


Access is a Desktop application, not a client-server one, and hence is not scalable for use over a wide network. It uses tables, forms, queries, and reports to store, manipulate, and access data. Here we are going to describe how to use these data elements to create and manipulate a database consisting of student records for a coaching academy. This is an example; Access can be used by a wide variety of small-and medium-sized businesses like bookshops, travel agencies, clinics, restaurants, etc. to store and handle data. In cases



Here's how to create a database in Access

where the database or the number of users becomes too large for Access to handle, it can be upsized by linking the front-end of the database (the user interface) with enterprise-level database management tools (like Microsoft SQL Server, Oracle, or MySQL, like we mentioned).

Tables

Tables are the backbone of any database management system—data is typically stored in tab-

ular form in a database. This is also the case with Access. To start storing data, open Access and select File > New. Click on Blank database, enter a name for your database, and save it. A Database window pops up showing all the elements in an Access database.



The database window is your primary handle on Access

You have three options there—Create table in Design View, Create table by using wizard and Create table by entering data. We don't recommend using the Wizard—it looks simple and is tempting, but you can easily foul up and have to return to square one. Use either the first or the third option. For beginners, the third option might be the best, but once you get the hang of it, you will be benefited by creating your table in Design view.

For our student record database we created two tables—student info and fees, using Design view. A tip: design the layout of your tables on paper before you get cracking at the computer. Think about all the fields you need to put in a

Access 2007—What's New?

Access 2007 is part of the newly-released Microsoft Office 2007, which had been timed for release along with Vista. As with other Office 2007 components, Access 2007 has been packed with a lot of new and useful features. Here is a low-down on some of them:

New look and feel: Access 2007 has a completely revamped look and feel. The "Getting started" page is a completely new experience compared to that in the earlier edition. The Ribbon—one of the most widely-talked about features in Office 2007—is used inside Access, replacing all the old-style menus, buttons, and toolbars. The benefit of the Ribbon is you don't need to dig deep into the menus to find out a particular option; the Ribbon displays it to the user according to the context. You get lots of slick templates to choose from—this gives your user interface that "cool" look. Also, Access now implements the Single Document Interface, where forms and reports open in new tabs.

New formats: The databases generated by Access 2007 are in a new format, .accdb. Old-style .mdb databases can be opened in Access 2007, but .accdb files cannot be opened by Access 2003.

Easier database construction: Access 2007 automatically assigns data types to fields entered in a database. This is a very useful feature for users who are not clear whether they ought to use, say, text or number as the data type for phone numbers.

New Form and report authoring tools: A new WYSIWYG editor presents itself. It lets users see, during design, what their final reports and forms will look like. This feature saves a lot of time otherwise spent in redesigning the look of the reports and forms. Exporting them to PDF format is a mouse click away. You can incorporate .png or .jpg images without increasing the size of the database and make your tables look prettier by colouring alternate rows in different colours.

Search capabilities: A search box enables you to search any field in datasheets and forms. This feature is useful especially with large documents.

Access 2007, though a big improvement over its previous avatar, suffers from quite a few bugs like compatibility and interface issues. There are also doubts as to how it will work with forms, pages, etc. prepared using Access 2003. As of now, therefore, most people are adopting the wait-and-watch policy regarding the use of Access 2007.